

The Gentle Way: An Exploration of the Art, Philosophy, and Global Impact of Judo

Introduction

Judo (柔道, Jūdō), meaning "the gentle way," stands as more than a globally recognized Olympic sport or a system of self-defense. It represents a holistic method of physical, intellectual, and moral education, conceived and meticulously developed by its founder, Professor Jigoro Kano. Originating in late 19th-century Japan, Judo synthesized traditional martial arts principles with modern educational philosophies, creating a unique pathway for personal development and societal contribution. Its emphasis on maximizing efficiency while fostering mutual welfare has allowed it to transcend cultural boundaries, achieving significant global reach with millions of practitioners and a prominent place in international sport. This report provides a comprehensive exploration of Judo, delving into its historical origins under Jigoro Kano, its guiding philosophical principles, its diverse technical repertoire, the structured ranking system, its dual nature as both a competitive sport and a traditional martial art, the multifaceted benefits of its practice, its governing structures, and its enduring legacy and influence on other martial arts and global culture.

I. The Genesis of Judo: Jigoro Kano and the Kodokan

The creation and development of Judo are inextricably linked to the life, intellect, and vision of its founder, Jigoro Kano. Understanding his background and motivations is crucial to appreciating the unique character of the art he established.

A. Jigoro Kano: Educator, Visionary, Founder (1860-1938)

Jigoro Kano was born on October 28, 1860, in Mikage, near Kobe, Japan, into an affluent family known for sake brewing. Following his mother's death and his father's appointment as a government official, the family moved to Tokyo in 1871. Academically gifted, Kano excelled in his studies, particularly languages, eventually graduating from Tokyo Imperial University (now Tokyo University) in 1881 with degrees in literature, politics, and political economy. His intellectual prowess was notable; many of his developmental notes on Judo were written in English, partly for privacy amidst rivalries, but also to foster new ways of thinking.

Despite his academic success, Kano was physically frail in his youth, standing around 5 feet 2 inches and weighing approximately 90-95 pounds (41kg). He frequently experienced bullying, which became a primary motivator for seeking ways to improve his health and learn self-defense. This personal quest led him to the study of Jujutsu.

Kano's identity as an educator profoundly shaped Judo. He pursued a distinguished career in education, serving as Director of Primary Education for the Ministry of Education (1898-1901) and President of Tokyo Higher Normal School (1900-1920). This background instilled in him a focus that extended beyond mere combat effectiveness. He envisioned a system that could serve as a comprehensive form of physical, mental, and moral education, contributing to individual self-perfection and the betterment of society. This educational imperative is evident in the very structure and philosophy of Judo, differentiating it from the purely martial focus of many older Jujutsu schools. His selection of names like "Kodokan" (Place for Expounding the Way) and "Judo" (Gentle Way) further underscored this educational mission.

Kano was also an internationalist and a pioneer in Japanese sports. Appointed as the first Asian member of the International Olympic Committee (IOC) in 1909, he served until his death in 1938. He represented Japan at multiple Olympic Games and played a crucial role in establishing the Japan Amateur Athletic Association. Often called the "Father of Japanese Sports," he undertook numerous international journeys (at least eight major trips) to lecture on and demonstrate Judo, laying the groundwork for its global dissemination. Jigoro Kano passed away at sea aboard the Hikawa Maru on May 4, 1938.

B. From Jujutsu to Judo: Synthesizing Tradition

Judo emerged from the rich tapestry of traditional Japanese martial arts known collectively as Jujutsu (or Jiu-Jitsu). Practiced by the samurai class during Japan's feudal period, Jujutsu encompassed a wide array of techniques including throws, grappling holds, joint locks, and strikes, taught within various schools (*ryu*). With the Meiji Restoration in 1868 and the dissolution of the samurai class, many traditional martial arts, including Jujutsu, faced a period of decline.

It was during this era that Kano began his martial arts journey. Driven by his desire for self-improvement, he sought out Jujutsu masters, eventually studying diligently under several prominent teachers. His primary influences came from:

- **Tenjin Shin'yō-ryū:** First under Fukuda Hachinosuke, who emphasized practical application (*randori*) over formal exercises (*kata*). After Fukuda's death, Kano studied under Iso Masatomo, who placed greater emphasis on *kata*. This school strongly influenced Judo's grappling techniques (*Katame-waza*).
- **Kitō-ryū:** Under Iikubo Tsunetoshi, Kano learned techniques emphasizing throws (*Nage-waza*) and explored the spiritual dimensions of martial practice. Kitō-ryū significantly shaped Judo's throwing repertoire.

Around 1880, Kano began a systematic process of analyzing and rethinking the techniques he had learned. He found existing Jujutsu schools often lacked a unifying theoretical principle and a robust philosophical foundation. He sought to create a new system based on scientific principles, integrating the most effective techniques from various *ryu* while discarding elements he deemed inefficient or overly dangerous. His search for a core principle led him to *Seiryoku Zen'yō* (Maximum Efficiency). Crucially, Kano aimed to develop a method that could serve not only as a means of combat or self-defense but also as a form of physical education and moral development, suitable for widespread practice, including in schools. This involved removing or modifying dangerous techniques, particularly many striking methods and certain joint locks, to ensure safer practice.

The name "Judo" itself reflects this transformation. Kano deliberately chose *Judo* (柔道 - Gentle Way) over *Jujutsu* (柔術 - Gentle Art/Technique). The substitution of *dō* (道 - way, path, doctrine) for *jutsu* (術 - art, technique, skill) signified a shift in emphasis from mere technical proficiency to a lifelong path of learning, self-cultivation, and ethical conduct. It elevated the practice from a combat method to a way of life.

C. The Founding and Growth of the Kodokan Institute

In February 1882, at the age of 22, Jigoro Kano established his own training hall, the Kodokan (講道館), initially housed in a small 12-mat room at the Eishoji Buddhist temple in Tokyo. He started with just nine students. His former Kitō-ryū instructor, Iikubo Tsunetoshi, assisted with teaching in the early days.

The name "Kodokan" translates as "Place for Expounding the Way" (*kō* - lecture/study/method, *dō* - way/path, *kan* - hall/place). This name explicitly reinforces the educational and philosophical mission Kano envisioned for his institution, distinguishing it from traditional Jujutsu dojos solely focused on combat training.

The Kodokan experienced significant growth, necessitating several relocations to larger premises over the years. Its reputation was solidified through successes in challenge matches and tournaments against established Jujutsu schools, notably contests organized by the Tokyo Metropolitan Police, which eventually adopted Judo as its primary martial art. The Kodokan became an official foundation in 1909. Today, the Kodokan remains the global headquarters of Judo, housed in an eight-story building in Tokyo featuring over 1,200 mats across multiple dojos. It continues to function as the premier institution for Judo instruction, rank certification, technical development, and the preservation of Kano's teachings. The Kodokan Cultural Judo Society, established in 1922, further promotes the philosophical and cultural aspects of Judo.

D. Early Development and Spread in Japan

Kano worked diligently to systematize his new art. He classified the throwing techniques into the *Go Kyo No Waza* (Five Sets of Techniques) in 1895 (later revised in 1920), providing a structured curriculum for instruction. In 1900, he established the Kodokan Yudanshakai (Association of Black Belt Holders), formalizing the rank structure. This standardization was key to Judo's effective dissemination.

Leveraging his position as a leading educator, Kano successfully campaigned to include Judo (along with Kendo) in the physical education curriculum of Japanese public schools during the 1910s. This integration significantly broadened Judo's reach and embedded it within the national education system. By 1905, Judo's prominence was such that leading masters from various Jujutsu *ryu* convened at the Butokukai in Kyoto and formally recognized Kano's system, marking Judo's effective triumph over older Jujutsu forms within Japan.

II. The Philosophical Pillars: Seiryoku Zen'yō and Jita Kyōei

Beyond the physical techniques, the essence of Judo lies in its two guiding philosophical principles, conceived by Jigoro Kano not merely as abstract ideals but as practical guides for action both within the dojo and in everyday life. These principles elevate Judo from a mere combat system to a comprehensive method for self-improvement and societal contribution.

A. Seiryoku Zen'yō: Maximum Efficiency, Minimum Effort Explained

The first principle, *Seiryoku Zen'yō* (精力善用), translates to "Maximum efficient use of energy" or "Maximum efficiency, minimum effort". It signifies the most effective utilization of both physical power and mental or spiritual energy to achieve a purpose.

This concept has roots in traditional Jujutsu principles, particularly *jū yoku gō o seisu* (柔よく剛を制す), meaning "softness controls hardness" or "flexibility overcomes rigidity". In the context of Judo techniques (*waza*), *Seiryoku Zen'yō* dictates that attack and defense should be based on using the opponent's force, momentum, and balance against them. By applying leverage correctly and timing actions precisely, a practitioner can achieve maximum effect with the minimum expenditure of their own strength. This is exemplified in the importance of *Kuzushi* (breaking the opponent's balance) before attempting a throw (*Tsukuri* and *Kake*), making the technique far more efficient. This emphasis on efficiency makes Judo accessible and effective regardless of disparities in size or strength between opponents.

Kano realized, however, that the application of *Seiryoku Zen'yō* extended far beyond physical combat. He saw it as a universal principle applicable to all aspects of life: self-improvement, education, work, social interactions, and administration. It encourages the wise and efficient use of one's total energy – physical, mental, and spiritual – towards a "good purpose," which Kano linked directly to the second principle, *Jita Kyōei*.

B. Jita Kyōei: Mutual Welfare and Benefit Explored

The second core principle, *Jita Kyōei* (自他共栄), means "Mutual welfare and benefit" or "Mutual prosperity for self and others". This principle underscores the interdependence of individuals within society and emphasizes the importance of cooperation, harmony, mutual respect, and

mutual aid for collective progress.

Jita Kyōei provides the ethical framework for *Seiryoku Zen'yō*. It defines the "good purpose" towards which one's energy should be efficiently directed. Actions that contribute to the development and well-being of the community and society are considered "good," while actions that hinder this progress are "bad". By achieving one's own goals efficiently (*Seiryoku Zen'yō*), an individual becomes better equipped to contribute positively to the welfare of others, leading to mutual prosperity (*Jita Kyōei*). Conversely, acting solely out of self-interest, without regard for others, is ultimately inefficient and counterproductive, leading to conflict and potential self-destruction.

In the practical setting of the dojo, *Jita Kyōei* is fundamental. It manifests in the expectation that training partners treat each other with respect, prioritize safety, and actively help one another learn and improve. Progress is understood as a shared endeavor. A judoka who trains recklessly or refuses to assist others is not truly practicing Judo according to its core philosophy. Even the judogi (uniform) can be seen through this lens: by providing grips, practitioners symbolically offer their partners the means to practice techniques, trusting in mutual care and shared learning.

C. Application in Practice and Life: The Transition to "Do"

Together, *Seiryoku Zen'yō* and *Jita Kyōei* form the philosophical bedrock of Judo and guided Kano's refinement of Jujutsu into a *budō* (martial way) rather than just a *bujutsu* (martial art). Techniques that did not align with these principles, particularly those relying on brute force or causing unnecessary harm without a corresponding benefit to skill development or understanding, were rejected or modified.

Kano firmly believed that the practice of Judo techniques, through methods like *Kata* (pre-arranged forms) and *Randori* (free practice), served as a practical laboratory for internalizing these fundamental principles. The physical discipline and challenges of training were intended to cultivate mental discipline, ethical understanding, and ultimately, a perfected character capable of contributing positively to society. In this way, Judo becomes more than just a set of physical skills; it offers guiding principles applicable to the myriad facets of human life. The Judo Moral Code, often summarized by values such as Politeness, Courage, Sincerity, Honour, Modesty, Respect, Self-Control, and Friendship, provides concrete ethical guidelines that embody these core philosophies in action. The physical practice is thus intrinsically linked to the philosophical aims; one serves as the vehicle for realizing the other, fostering holistic human development.

III. The Technical Repertoire: Waza of Judo

Judo's technical foundation, or *waza* (技), is broadly categorized into three main groups: throwing techniques (*Nage-waza*), grappling techniques (*Katame-waza*), and striking techniques (*Atemi-waza*). While modern sport Judo heavily emphasizes the first two, understanding all three provides a complete picture of the art's scope and origins.

A. Nage-waza (投げ技): Throwing Techniques

Nage-waza constitute the most iconic and visually spectacular aspect of Judo. These techniques aim to disrupt an opponent's (*Uke*'s) balance (*Kuzushi*), position oneself (*Tori*) effectively (*Tsukuri*), and execute a throw (*Kake*), ideally landing the opponent cleanly on their back. This category draws heavily from the throwing emphasis of the Kitō-ryū Jujutsu tradition studied by Kano. *Nage-waza* are divided into two main classifications:

1. **Tachi-waza (立技): Standing Techniques:** Performed while the thrower (*Tori*) maintains a standing position. These are further subdivided based on the primary body part used:
 - **Te-waza (手技): Hand Techniques:** Primarily utilizing arm and hand movements. Examples include *Ippon Seoinage* (one-arm shoulder throw), *Tai Otoshi* (body

- drop), and *Kata Guruma* (shoulder wheel).
- **Koshi-waza (腰技): Hip Techniques:** Employing the hips as the main fulcrum for the throw. Examples include *Harai Goshi* (sweeping hip throw), *O Goshi* (full hip throw), *Uki Goshi* (floating hip throw), and *Tsuri Goshi* (lifting hip throw).
- **Ashi-waza (足技): Foot and Leg Techniques:** Using the legs and feet to reap, sweep, block, or trip the opponent. Examples include *Osoto Gari* (large outer reap), *Ouchi Gari* (large inner reap), *Uchi Mata* (inner thigh throw), *Deashi Harai* (advanced foot sweep), *Hiza Guruma* (knee wheel), and *Sasae Tsurikomi Ashi* (propping drawing ankle throw).
- 2. **Sutemi-waza (捨身技): Sacrifice Techniques:** Involve *Tori* intentionally sacrificing their own upright posture to execute a throw. These are divided based on the direction of the sacrifice:
 - **Ma-sutemi-waza (真捨身技): Rear Sacrifice Techniques:** *Tori* falls backward to execute the throw. Examples include *Tomoe Nage* (circular throw), *Sumi Gaeshi* (corner reversal), and *Ura Nage* (rear throw).
 - **Yoko-sutemi-waza (横捨身技): Side Sacrifice Techniques:** *Tori* falls onto their side to execute the throw. Examples include *Yoko Otoshi* (side drop), *Tani Otoshi* (valley drop), *Uki Waza* (floating technique), and *Yoko Guruma* (side wheel).

The Kodokan standardized the teaching of throws through the *Go Kyo no Waza* (Five Sets of Techniques), a syllabus comprising 40 core throws organized into five groups (Dai Ikkyo, Dai Nikyo, Dai Sankyo, Dai Yonkyo, Dai Gokyo), representing a progression of learning.

B. Katame-waza (固技): Grappling Techniques

Katame-waza encompass the ground-fighting aspects of Judo, often referred to as *Ne-waza* (寝技 - techniques performed lying down). These techniques aim to control, immobilize, or force the submission of an opponent on the ground. This category shows a stronger influence from the Tenjin Shin'yō-ryū tradition. *Katame-waza* are divided into three groups:

1. **Osaekomi-waza (抑込技): Holding/Pinning Techniques:** Techniques used to pin and control an opponent on their back on the mat. In competition, holding an opponent for a specific duration (currently 20 seconds for *Ippon*, 10-19 seconds for *Waza-ari*) results in a score. Examples include *Kesa Gatame* (scarf hold), *Kami Shiho Gatame* (upper four corner hold), *Yoko Shiho Gatame* (side four corner hold), and *Tate Shiho Gatame* (vertical four corner hold).
2. **Shime-waza (絞技): Choking/Strangling Techniques:** Techniques that apply pressure to the opponent's neck or carotid arteries, restricting blood flow or air, to induce submission. Examples include *Nami Juji Jime* (normal cross strangle), *Hadaka Jime* (naked choke), *Okuri Eri Jime* (sliding collar choke), and *Sode Guruma Jime* (sleeve wheel choke, also known as the Ezekiel choke).
3. **Kansetsu-waza (関節技): Joint Locking Techniques:** Techniques that hyperextend or twist an opponent's joint beyond its normal range of motion, causing pain and forcing submission. In modern IJF competition rules, *Kansetsu-waza* are restricted solely to targeting the elbow joint. However, locks targeting other joints (wrist, shoulder, knee, ankle) exist within traditional Judo and are preserved in *Kata*. Examples include *Ude Hishigi Juji Gatame* (cross arm lock) and *Ude Garami* (entangled arm lock or keylock).

Historically, Kano initially reserved the teaching of *Shime-waza* and *Kansetsu-waza* for students who had attained higher ranks, considering them more dangerous than basic holds.

C. Atemi-waza (当て身技): Striking Techniques

Atemi-waza refers to techniques involving striking vital points on the opponent's body. These strikes can be delivered using various body parts, including fists, open hands (fingertips,

hand-edge), elbows, knees, feet (heel, ball of foot), and even the head. They are broadly categorized into *Ude-ate* (arm strikes) and *Ashi-ate* (leg/foot strikes). Examples include front kicks (*Mae-geri*), side kicks (*Yoko-geri*), uppercuts (*Tsukiage*), downward strikes (*Kirioroshi*), and headbutts (*Atama-ate*).

Atemi-waza were an integral part of the classical Jujutsu systems from which Judo evolved and were included by Kano in the original Judo framework, considered essential for realistic combat scenarios. However, recognizing their inherent danger and potential lethality, Kano significantly restricted their practice within his developing system. Their instruction was often reserved for high-ranking Judoka and primarily confined to the practice of *Kata* (pre-arranged forms), such as the *Kime-no-Kata* (Forms of Decision) and *Kodokan Goshin Jutsu* (Kodokan Self-Defense Forms).

Crucially, *Atemi-waza* are strictly forbidden in Judo competition (*Shiai*) and free practice (*Randori*) due to safety concerns. This exclusion clearly demonstrates the prioritization of safety and educational goals (*Do*) over pure combat realism (*Jutsu*) in the mainstream practice of Judo. While removing strikes from daily training made Judo safer and suitable for sport and physical education, their preservation within *Kata* allows the art to retain its connection to its martial roots and maintain a comprehensive self-defense dimension for advanced practitioners. This careful balancing act reflects Kano's intent to create a system that was both safe for broad participation and grounded in effective martial principles.

D. Related Concepts

Two other essential concepts related to Judo technique are:

- **Ukemi (受け身): Breakfall Techniques:** Learning how to fall correctly (forward, backward, sideways, rolling) is fundamental to Judo training. Mastering *Ukemi* is crucial for safety, allowing practitioners to absorb the impact of throws without injury, enabling vigorous practice of *Nage-waza*.
- **Kappo (活法): Resuscitation Techniques:** Traditional methods of reviving individuals who may have been rendered unconscious, particularly through *Shime-waza*. The teaching of *Kappo* often accompanied instruction in potentially dangerous techniques, emphasizing the responsibility associated with such knowledge.

IV. Measuring Progress: The Judo Ranking System

Jigoro Kano introduced a structured ranking system to Judo in 1883, awarding the first *Shodan* (first-degree black belt) ranks to two senior students, Shiro Saigo and Tsunejiro Tomita. This marked a significant innovation, as Judo became the first Japanese martial art to adopt the *Kyu* (級 - grade) and *Dan* (段 - degree/level) system, inspired by ranking systems used in the traditional board games Go and Shogi. The purpose of this system is to formally recognize a practitioner's level of proficiency, provide a structured pathway for learning, and offer motivation for continued development. Advancement through the ranks ideally reflects progress not only in technical skill (*Tai*) but also in theoretical understanding (*Ghi*) and moral/spiritual development (*Shin*).

A. Kyu Grades (級): The Student Path

The *Kyu* ranks represent the levels below black belt, signifying the student phase of learning. These grades are counted in descending order, typically from 6th *Kyu* (*Rokkyu*) down to 1st *Kyu* (*Ikkyu*). Beginners start as *Mukyu* (ungraded) or are awarded 6th *Kyu*. Practitioners holding *Kyu* grades are known as *Mudansha* (無段者 - person without Dan).

The belt colors associated with *Kyu* grades have evolved and vary significantly internationally. The original Kodokan system was relatively austere, primarily using a white belt for lower *Kyu* grades (e.g., 6th to 4th *Kyu*) and a brown belt for the higher *Kyu* grades (3rd to 1st *Kyu*). However, particularly in Western countries, a more graduated system of colored belts was

introduced, largely popularized by instructors like Mikonosuke Kawaishi in Europe and the Budokwai in London in the 1920s and 1930s. This system typically includes colors such as yellow, orange, green, blue, and purple, in addition to white and brown, providing more frequent visual markers of progress and incentives for students, especially younger ones. Some national systems also employ two-tone belts (e.g., white-yellow, yellow-orange) to denote intermediate steps. The specific sequence and colors used for *Kyu* ranks remain diverse across different countries and organizations.

Promotion through the *Kyu* ranks is generally handled at the local club or dojo level, awarded by the instructor (*Sensei*). Criteria typically involve demonstrating required techniques, understanding fundamental principles, regular attendance and participation, adherence to dojo etiquette and the Judo moral code, and sometimes performance in club-level competitions or assessments.

B. Dan Grades (段): The Master Path

The *Dan* grades signify the attainment of black belt level and beyond, representing a mastery of the fundamentals and readiness for deeper study. Practitioners holding *Dan* grades are known as *Yudansha* (有段者 - person with Dan). *Dan* ranks are counted in ascending order, starting from 1st *Dan* (*Shodan*).

The belt colors for *Dan* grades are more standardized globally, although variations exist:

- **1st *Dan* (*Shodan*) to 5th *Dan* (*Godan*):** Black Belt (*Kuro obi*).
- **6th *Dan* (*Rokudan*) to 8th *Dan* (*Hachidan*):** Option of wearing either a black belt or a distinctive Red and White paneled belt (*Kohaku obi*). This belt was introduced by the Kodokan around 1930 to recognize the advanced status and contributions of high-ranking *Yudansha*.
- **9th *Dan* (*Kudan*) and 10th *Dan* (*Judan*):** Option of wearing a black belt, the red and white belt, or a solid Red belt (*Aka obi*). The red belt was created by the Kodokan in 1943 for these highest ranks.

While Kano originally conceived of the possibility of ranks beyond 10th *Dan* (theoretically up to 12th *Dan*, potentially returning to a white belt to symbolize the cycle of learning), the Kodokan has never promoted anyone beyond 10th *Dan*. Only a very small number of individuals (15 as of historical records) have ever been awarded the prestigious 10th *Dan* by the Kodokan. The International Judo Federation (IJF) also has provisions for awarding 10th *Dan*, requiring unanimous approval from its Executive Committee.

Promotion to *Dan* grades is a more formalized process than *Kyu* promotions. It typically requires examination supervised by regional or national Judo associations (National Governing Bodies - NGBs) or the Kodokan itself. Requirements usually include a high level of technical proficiency demonstrated in *waza* and *kata*, often success in official competitions (accumulating points), theoretical knowledge (tested through written or oral exams), minimum age requirements, and minimum time spent in the previous rank (time-in-grade). For higher *Dan* grades (typically 6th *Dan* and above), factors such as teaching experience, coaching achievements, refereeing qualifications, administrative contributions to Judo, and overall character and adherence to Judo's principles (*Shin*) become increasingly important. The IJF has established specific pathways and criteria for the international recognition of high *Dan* grades, often involving review by continental and international commissions. For a *Dan* rank to be officially recognized internationally, it generally must be registered with the practitioner's NGB and potentially the Kodokan or IJF.

C. Variations and Standardization

It is important to note the significant international variation in *Kyu* belt colors and sometimes the number of *Kyu* ranks, reflecting adaptations to different pedagogical needs and cultural

contexts. The introduction of multiple colors in the West, diverging from the simpler Kodokan tradition, aimed to provide more frequent reinforcement and visible milestones for students. This evolution highlights Judo's adaptability. In contrast, the *Dan* ranking system and its associated black, red-and-white, and red belts are considerably more standardized worldwide, although specific promotion requirements still differ between national organizations.

Table 1: Judo Kyu and Dan Ranks Overview

Rank Category	Rank Level	Japanese Name	Typical Kodokan Belt	Common Int'l Kyu Belt Colors (Examples)	High Dan Belt Options	Notes
Kyu (Grade)	6th Kyu	Rokkyū	White	White, Yellow, Red (UK Jr.)		Starting rank for many
	5th Kyu	Gokyū	White	Yellow, Orange		
	4th Kyu	Yonkyū	White	Orange, Green		
	3rd Kyu	Sankyū	Brown	Green, Blue, Purple		Often first colored belt in stricter systems
	2nd Kyu	Nikyū	Brown	Blue, Purple, Brown		
	1st Kyu	Ikkyū	Brown	Brown		Highest Kyu rank
Dan (Degree)	1st Dan	Shodan	Black		Black	First black belt rank
	2nd Dan	Nidan	Black		Black	
	3rd Dan	Sandan	Black		Black	
	4th Dan	Yondan	Black		Black	
	5th Dan	Godan	Black		Black	
	6th Dan	Rokudan	Black		Black or Red & White	Kōdansha (High Rank Holder) begins
	7th Dan	Shichidan	Black		Black or Red & White	
	8th Dan	Hachidan	Black		Black or Red & White	
	9th Dan	Kudan	Black		Black, Red & White, or Red	Extremely high rank, few holders
	10th Dan	Jūdan	Black		Black, Red & White, or Red	Highest rank awarded by Kodokan/IJF (15 Kodokan

Rank Category	Rank Level	Japanese Name	Typical Kodokan Belt	Common Int'l Kyu Belt Colors (Examples)	High Dan Belt Options	Notes
						recipients historically)
	11th Dan & Higher	Jūichidan etc.	(Theoretical)		(Theoretical: Red/White)	Conceived by Kano but never awarded

Note: Kyu belt color systems vary widely. The "Common Int'l" column shows typical colors used in many Western systems but is not universal.

V. Duality of Practice: Sport vs. Traditional Martial Art

Modern Judo exists in two primary, often overlapping, spheres: as a highly codified Olympic sport and as a traditional martial art (*Budo*) encompassing self-defense and philosophical development. While both stem from Jigoro Kano's original creation, they emphasize different aspects of his vision and operate under different frameworks.

A. Judo as an Olympic Sport

Judo's inclusion in the Olympic Games, starting with the 1964 Tokyo Games for men and officially adding women's competition in Barcelona 1992 (following a demonstration event in Seoul 1988), marked a pivotal moment in its globalization. A mixed team event was introduced for the Tokyo 2020 Games.

Olympic and international sport Judo operates under rules established and periodically revised by the International Judo Federation (IJF). The primary objective in competition is to score points by successfully executing *Nage-waza* (throws) or achieving dominance through *Katame-waza* (grappling techniques). Key aspects of sport Judo include:

- **Scoring:** The highest score is *Ippon* (一本 - full point), which immediately ends the match. It can be awarded for a clean, forceful throw landing the opponent largely on their back; for pinning the opponent (*Osaekomi*) for 20 seconds; or for forcing a submission via *Shime-waza* (choke) or *Kansetsu-waza* (arm lock). A lesser score, *Waza-ari* (技あり - technique almost complete), is awarded for throws lacking full criteria for *Ippon* or for pins lasting 10-19 seconds. Accumulating two *Waza-ari* also results in victory (equivalent to *Ippon*). Older scores like *Yuko* and *Koka* have been eliminated from IJF rules.
- **Penalties:** Infractions are penalized with *Shido* (指導 - guidance/minor penalty). Examples include excessive passivity, illegal grips, deliberately stepping out of bounds, or minor rule violations. Accumulating three *Shido* results in disqualification (*Hansoku-make* 反則負け - foul-play loss). Direct *Hansoku-make* can be given for major breaches, such as performing forbidden techniques, actions dangerous to the opponent, or unsportsmanlike conduct.
- **Allowed Techniques:** Competition focuses on the established *Nage-waza* techniques and specific *Katame-waza*, namely *Osaekomi-waza*, *Shime-waza*, and *Kansetsu-waza* applied only to the elbow joint.
- **Forbidden Techniques:** To ensure safety and promote a specific style of contest, many techniques are prohibited in competition. This includes all *Atemi-waza* (strikes), direct attacks to the legs with the hands (leg grabs - banned in most circumstances under recent rules), joint locks targeting joints other than the elbow, certain dangerous throws like *Kani Basami* (crab scissors) and *Kawazu Gake* (one-leg entanglement), and neck cranks.

- **Match Structure:** Matches have a set duration (currently 4 minutes for both men and women in senior IJF events). If scores are tied at the end of regulation time, the match enters an unlimited "Golden Score" period, where the first score or penalty decides the winner.
- **Rule Evolution:** IJF rules are subject to change, often aiming to encourage more dynamic throwing (*Tachi-waza*), reduce periods of inactivity or defensive play, enhance spectator understanding, and improve safety. The relatively recent ban on most direct leg grabs, for instance, significantly altered competitive strategies.

B. Judo as Budo: Traditional Practice, Self-Defense Aspects, Kata

Beyond the confines of sport rules, Judo is practiced as a *Budo* – a martial way focused on holistic development. This perspective embraces the entirety of Kano's system, including aspects deemphasized or excluded from competition:

- **Comprehensive Technique:** Traditional practice acknowledges and may include the study of the full range of Judo techniques, including *Atemi-waza* and a wider variety of *Kansetsu-waza* (joint locks), often within the context of self-defense scenarios or *Kata*.
- **Self-Defense Application:** The emphasis shifts towards practical effectiveness in real-world self-protection situations, potentially involving attackers of different sizes or those using weapons. The core principles of *Seiryoku Zen'yō* (using an opponent's force, leverage) are central to this application. Defenses against strikes and weapons are specifically preserved and practiced within certain *Kata*.
- **Central Role of Kata (形):** *Kata* are pre-arranged sequences of techniques performed with a partner, serving as a repository for Judo's principles, techniques (including those too dangerous for *Randori*), and historical lineage. They are essential for developing a deep understanding of technique mechanics, timing, and the underlying philosophy. Recognized Kodokan *Kata* include *Randori-no-Kata* (*Nage-no-Kata* - forms of throwing, *Katame-no-Kata* - forms of grappling), *Kime-no-Kata* (forms of decision/self-defense against attacks), *Kodokan Goshin Jutsu* (modern self-defense forms), *Ju-no-Kata* (forms of gentleness), *Itsutsu-no-Kata* (the five forms), *Koshiki-no-Kata* (ancient forms), and *Seiryoku Zen'yō Kokumin Taiiku no Kata* (maximum-efficiency national physical education forms). Proficiency in specific *Kata* is a common requirement for *Dan* promotions.
- **Philosophical Depth:** The *Budo* aspect strongly emphasizes the *Do* (Way) – the pursuit of self-perfection through rigorous training, the cultivation of character (discipline, respect, humility, courage), and the application of Judo's principles (*Seiryoku Zen'yō*, *Jita Kyōei*) to improve oneself and contribute positively to society.

C. Key Differences and Complementary Aspects

The distinction between sport Judo and traditional Judo/Budo lies primarily in their objectives and the scope of techniques practiced. Sport Judo operates within a specific, evolving rule set designed for safe, fair, and engaging competition, prioritizing techniques effective under those constraints. Traditional Judo/Budo adheres more broadly to Kano's foundational principles, preserves the complete technical syllabus (including dangerous techniques within *Kata*), and emphasizes holistic self-development and practical self-defense.

However, these two aspects are not necessarily mutually exclusive but can be seen as complementary facets of Kano's comprehensive vision. The dynamic, unpredictable nature of *Randori* and *Shiai* (sport practice) develops crucial attributes like timing, reaction, strategic thinking under pressure, resilience, and the ability to apply techniques against resisting opponents. The methodical practice of *Kata* and the study of traditional principles provide a deeper understanding of technique mechanics, historical context, self-defense applications, and the philosophical underpinnings of the art. Many dedicated Judoka engage deeply in both

competitive training and traditional practice, finding that each enhances the understanding and execution of the other. The divergence, therefore, reflects Judo's successful adaptation to fulfill different needs – standardized international sport on one hand, and a comprehensive system for education and self-defense on the other – both originating from Kano's multifaceted intentions.

Table 2: Comparison of Sport Judo and Traditional Judo/Budo

Key Aspect	Olympic/Sport Judo	Traditional Judo/Budo/Self-Defense
Primary Goal	Win matches under IJF rules via points (<i>Waza-ari</i> , <i>Ippon</i>) or submission.	Holistic self-development (physical, mental, moral), practical self-defense capability, understanding principles.
Governing Factor	Specific, evolving IJF competition rules.	Core principles (<i>Seiryoku Zen'yō, Jita Kyōei</i>), full technical syllabus.
Allowed Techniques	Restricted set of <i>Nage-waza</i> , <i>Osaekomi-waza</i> , <i>Shime-waza</i> , elbow <i>Kansetsu-waza</i> .	Full range of Judo techniques, including <i>Atemi-waza</i> and wider <i>Kansetsu-waza</i> (primarily in <i>Kata</i>).
Emphasis	High-percentage techniques effective under current rules, dynamic action, scoring.	Technical depth, efficiency, application of principles, character development, preservation of tradition.
Primary Training Methods	<i>Randori</i> (free practice), <i>Shiai</i> (competition), technique drilling (<i>Uchi-komi</i>).	<i>Kata</i> (forms), <i>Randori</i> , technique study, philosophical inquiry, self-defense drills.
Key Exclusions	<i>Atemi-waza</i> , most leg grabs, non-elbow joint locks, certain dangerous throws.	None fundamentally excluded, but dangerous techniques restricted to <i>Kata</i> or advanced study.

VI. Holistic Development: The Benefits of Judo Practice

Jigoro Kano envisioned Judo not merely as a method of combat but as a comprehensive system for developing the individual physically, mentally, and socially. Modern research and extensive anecdotal evidence support the realization of this vision, highlighting a wide array of benefits associated with dedicated Judo practice.

A. Physical Benefits

Regular Judo training offers significant physiological advantages:

- **Comprehensive Fitness:** Judo provides a demanding full-body workout, enhancing cardiovascular health, muscular strength (both upper and lower body), muscular endurance, flexibility, coordination, balance, and agility. Studies confirm improvements in overall functional fitness, which is crucial for performing daily activities effectively, especially as one ages.
- **Enhanced Motor Skills:** Research, particularly involving children and adolescents, demonstrates that consistent Judo practice leads to significant improvements in fundamental motor competencies, including locomotor skills (running, jumping), object control skills (throwing, catching – relevant to gripping and movement), and stability skills (balance, postural control), often exceeding improvements seen in control groups. Judo participation can help young people meet recommended daily physical activity levels.

- **Safe Falling Skills (Ukemi):** The systematic practice of *Ukemi* (breakfalls) is a unique and highly practical benefit of Judo. Learning to fall safely and effectively dissipates impact forces, significantly reducing the risk of injury not only within the dojo but also from accidental falls in everyday life. This skill is particularly valuable for preventing fall-related injuries in older adults.
- **Body Composition:** Consistent training can contribute positively to anthropometric measures, such as reductions in waist circumference, indicating improvements in body composition.

B. Mental and Cognitive Benefits

The mental discipline inherent in Judo training yields substantial cognitive and psychological rewards:

- **Discipline, Focus, and Self-Control:** The structured nature of Judo training, the requirement to learn complex techniques, adherence to dojo etiquette, and the need to manage oneself during practice and competition cultivate discipline, concentration, and self-control. Learning to manage emotions, such as frustration or anger, is an explicit part of Judo's moral teachings.
- **Confidence, Resilience, and Self-Esteem:** Mastering challenging techniques and developing practical self-defense skills builds self-confidence and self-efficacy. The process of facing challenges, experiencing setbacks (like being thrown repeatedly), and persevering fosters resilience – the ability to get back up and continue striving. Positive self-assessment and higher self-esteem are often associated with Judo practice.
- **Cognitive Function Enhancement:** Emerging research suggests Judo positively influences various cognitive domains:
 - *Executive Functions:* Studies indicate improvements in core executive functions such as attention control, working memory, cognitive flexibility, impulse inhibition (the ability to suppress inappropriate responses), strategic planning, and problem-solving abilities. This may be linked to the constant need for tactical decision-making and adaptation during *Randori*.
 - *Attention and Reaction Time:* Experienced judoka have shown different patterns of neuroelectrical activity during attention tasks, suggesting enhanced concentration and potentially faster reaction times.
 - *Stress Management:* The physical and mental demands of training, coupled with the application of principles like *Seiryoku Zen'yō* (efficiency under pressure), may enhance coping mechanisms for stress.
 - *Brain Health:* Some studies suggest potential benefits for overall brain health, possibly related to factors like increased Brain-Derived Neurotrophic Factor (BDNF), particularly observed in older practitioners.
- **Psychological Well-being:** While high-level competition can induce anxiety and pressure, learning to manage these psychological states is integral to development. Overall, Judo practice is associated with improved mental well-being and quality of life.

C. Social and Ethical Benefits

Judo places strong emphasis on social interaction and ethical conduct, fostering positive social development:

- **Respect and Politeness:** Respect for instructors (*Sensei*), training partners, opponents, and the training space itself is paramount in Judo culture, reinforced through rituals like bowing and adherence to strict etiquette.
- **Community and Friendship:** The shared challenges and cooperative nature of training often lead to strong bonds of camaraderie and friendship within the dojo, creating a

supportive community environment.

- **Mutual Welfare in Action (Jita Kyōei):** The principle of *Jita Kyōei* is not just taught but actively practiced. Training requires partners to work together cooperatively, ensuring each other's safety while facilitating mutual learning and technical development.
- **Character Development:** At its core, Judo aims to cultivate positive character traits such as honesty, integrity, humility, courage, and perseverance. This aligns directly with Kano's ultimate goal for Judo: to perfect the self in order to contribute meaningfully to society.

The convergence of these documented physical, mental, and social benefits provides strong validation for Jigoro Kano's original vision. He sought to create more than just an effective fighting method; he aimed to establish a comprehensive system for human development. The evidence suggests that Judo, when practiced with dedication and adherence to its principles, indeed functions as such a system, offering a pathway to improved health, sharper minds, and stronger character.

VII. Governance and Organization: Structuring Global Judo

The worldwide practice and standardization of Judo are overseen by a hierarchical structure of organizations, from the global governing body down to national federations and local clubs. This structure facilitates international competition, maintains technical standards, and promotes the art's growth.

A. The International Judo Federation (IJF)

The International Judo Federation (IJF) serves as the supreme international governing body for Judo. It was officially founded in London in July 1951, emerging from the existing European Judo Union (which itself had roots dating back to 1932) with the inclusion of Argentina. Although Jigoro Kano had envisioned an international organization earlier, his death and subsequent world events delayed its formation. Risei Kano, Jigoro Kano's son, served as an early president (appointed 1952). The current president is Marius Vizer (elected 2007), and the IJF headquarters is located in Budapest, Hungary.

The IJF comprises over 200 member National Judo Federations from across the globe, organized into five Continental Unions (Africa, Asia, Europe, Oceania, Pan-America). Its primary roles include:

- Establishing and enforcing the rules for international Judo competition, including Olympic qualification and participation.
- Organizing major international events, most notably the annual World Judo Championships (since 2009) and the IJF World Judo Tour, which consists of prestigious tournaments like Grand Slams, Grand Prix, and Masters events.
- Standardizing aspects of Judo globally, such as implementing an international Dan grade recognition system.
- Promoting Judo worldwide through various initiatives, including programs like Judo for Peace and Judo for Children.
- Overseeing the sport's ethical conduct and handling disciplinary matters, which has included addressing politically sensitive situations involving athletes and member nations.

The IJF operates through an Executive Committee and various specialized commissions, such as the Grade and Dan Rank Commission, responsible for validating high-level promotions.

B. National Governing Bodies (NGBs) (Example: USA Judo)

Within each member country, a National Governing Body (NGB) is responsible for overseeing Judo activities domestically. These NGBs must be recognized by their respective National Olympic Committees and are affiliated with both the IJF and their relevant Continental Union (e.g., the Pan American Judo Confederation - PJC for countries in the Americas). The NGB's mission typically involves promoting the growth of Judo within the country and enabling athletes

to achieve competitive excellence at both domestic and international levels.

USA Judo (officially United States Judo, Inc.) serves as the NGB for Judo in the United States.

As a non-profit organization headquartered at the U.S. Olympic & Paralympic Training Center in Colorado Springs, USA Judo is responsible for :

- Selecting and managing U.S. national teams for major international competitions, including the Olympic Games, Paralympic Games, and Pan American Championships.
- Sanctioning and organizing national-level tournaments, such as the Senior National Championships and the Junior Olympic Championships.
- Overseeing coach education, referee development, and the administration of the domestic ranking and promotion system.
- Managing club memberships and providing benefits such as participant insurance and access to training resources.
- Operating under a set of bylaws and policies, governed by a Board of Directors.

It is worth noting that while USA Judo holds the official NGB status recognized by the US Olympic & Paralympic Committee and the IJF, other longstanding national Judo organizations, such as the United States Judo Federation (USJF) and the United States Judo Association (USJA), also exist and contribute significantly to Judo in the U.S..

This hierarchical structure, flowing from the historical authority of the Kodokan, through the global IJF and its Continental Unions, down to the NGBs managing the sport within each country, and finally to the local clubs and dojos where practice occurs, provides a framework that allows for both global consistency (essential for international sport) and local administration and adaptation. This organized system has been instrumental in facilitating Judo's successful worldwide development and governance, enabling standardized competition while supporting grassroots growth.

VIII. Legacy and Influence: Judo's Global Footprint

Since its inception, Judo has exerted a profound influence, extending far beyond its own practice to shape other martial arts and leave a significant mark on global culture. Its successful dissemination is a testament to the effectiveness of Kano's vision and system.

A. Influence on Other Martial Arts

Judo served as a direct progenitor or significant influence for several other major martial arts and combat systems:

- **Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu (BJJ):** Perhaps the most famous derivative, BJJ traces its lineage directly back to Kodokan Judo. Mitsuyo Maeda, a prominent Judoka dispatched by Kano, taught Judo to Carlos Gracie in Brazil starting around 1914-1917. Carlos and his younger brother Hélio Gracie adapted Maeda's teachings, placing a much stronger emphasis on *Ne-waza* (ground techniques). They refined techniques focusing on leverage, ground control, and submissions (chokes and joint locks), specifically adapting them to allow smaller individuals to overcome larger opponents. BJJ's rules and technical emphasis arguably remained closer to early 20th-century Kodokan Judo, before subsequent IJF rule changes shifted the focus heavily towards *Tachi-waza* (standing throws) in sport Judo. BJJ is often considered Judo's "son" rather than merely sharing a common ancestor.
- **Sambo:** This Russian martial art, developed in the 1920s for military hand-to-hand combat, was heavily influenced by Judo. Vasili Oshchepkov, one of Sambo's founders, was a direct student of Jigoro Kano at the Kodokan and achieved a Nidan (2nd Dan) rank. Sambo integrated Judo principles and techniques with various indigenous wrestling styles from the Soviet Union. While sharing many throws and grappling maneuvers, Sambo developed distinct rules, notably allowing a wider range of leg locks in sport competition while historically forbidding chokes (though Combat Sambo includes strikes and chokes).

Some analyses view Sambo fundamentally as a distinct style or evolution of Judo, characterized by its more open rule set regarding permitted techniques ("catch-as-catch-can" principle) compared to Kodokan's codified list.

- **Aikido:** Although primarily derived from Daito-ryu Aiki-jujutsu, Aikido's founder, Morihei Ueshiba, also had exposure to Judo and interacted with Jigoro Kano. Both arts emerged during the same period of martial art modernization in Japan, evolving from older Jujutsu forms and sharing underlying principles related to blending with an opponent's force.
- **Other Systems:** Judo's principles and techniques have been incorporated into various other systems. Krav Maga, the Israeli self-defense system, includes Judo throws and grappling elements. Judo techniques are a common component of military and police close-quarters combat (CQC) training worldwide. The success of Judo and its derivatives like BJJ in challenge matches and early mixed martial arts (MMA) competitions fundamentally shaped the development of MMA, establishing grappling proficiency as essential. Furthermore, Gichin Funakoshi, the founder of Shotokan Karate, adopted Judo's *gi* (uniform) and the *Kyu/Dan* ranking system for Karate, seeking to gain acceptance for his art within the Japanese martial arts establishment.

B. Cultural Impact and Worldwide Practice

Judo holds the distinction of being one of the first Japanese martial arts to achieve widespread international recognition and practice. Several factors contributed to its successful global proliferation:

- **Systematic Design:** Kano created a well-structured curriculum (*Go Kyo no Waza*, ranking system) and a clear philosophical framework (*Seiryoku Zen'yō, Jita Kyōei*) that were readily teachable and adaptable across cultures.
- **Emphasis on Safety:** By removing or restricting the most dangerous techniques from common practice (*Randori*), Kano made Judo relatively safe and suitable for people of all ages, including children, facilitating its adoption as a form of physical education and sport.
- **Active Promotion:** Jigoro Kano himself, along with his dedicated disciples, actively traveled the world, giving demonstrations and establishing Judo schools in numerous countries. Judo also spread through Japanese emigrant communities.
- **Organizational Structure:** The establishment of the Kodokan as a central authority and later the IJF provided organizational frameworks for standardization and international governance.
- **Olympic Status:** Judo's inclusion as an Olympic sport dramatically increased its visibility, prestige, and participation rates globally.

Today, the IJF estimates that over 20 million people practice Judo worldwide. Thousands of clubs and dojos operate across nearly every country. Beyond its sporting dimension, Judo continues to be valued globally as an educational tool, promoting physical fitness, mental discipline, respect, and ethical conduct, thereby fulfilling the broad, humanistic vision of its founder. The global footprint of Judo, both in its direct practice and its influence on other disciplines, stands as a powerful testament to the enduring relevance and adaptability of Jigoro Kano's "gentle way."

Conclusion

Judo, born from Jigoro Kano's insightful synthesis of traditional Japanese Jujutsu and modern educational philosophy, has evolved into a truly global phenomenon. Its journey encompasses its development under a visionary founder, the establishment of the Kodokan as its central institution, the articulation of profound guiding principles, the codification of a sophisticated technical repertoire, and its bifurcation into a dynamic Olympic sport and a comprehensive martial way (*Budo*).

The art's enduring appeal lies in this multifaceted nature. As a sport, it offers a challenging and dynamic arena for physical competition, governed by rules that ensure safety while promoting spectacular displays of technique. As a *Budo*, it preserves a rich martial heritage, including techniques reserved for self-defense and formal study within *Kata*, while emphasizing a path of lifelong learning and character development. The core principles of *Seiryoku Zen'yō* (Maximum Efficiency, Minimum Effort) and *Jita Kyōei* (Mutual Welfare and Benefit) provide a timeless philosophical compass, guiding practitioners not only in their physical training but also in their approach to life beyond the mat. These principles, coupled with the tangible physical, mental, and social benefits consistently demonstrated through practice, validate Kano's aspiration to create more than just a fighting system, but a means for individuals to perfect themselves and contribute positively to the world. From its origins in late 19th-century Japan to its current status as a discipline practiced by millions worldwide and influencing countless other martial arts, Judo continues to embody the power and elegance of the "gentle way."

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